

so much certitude? It so happens that the essential ideas of the NEP are a near-verbatim reproduction of what had been devised and implemented at the University of Delhi during my time as its vice chancellor. The implementation and practice of our ideas resulted in undergraduates actively producing patents and research papers as well as launching startups. By the time my term as the vice chancellor ended, the functioning startups stemming from our implementation of the Four Year Undergraduate Programme had been valued at more than Rs 50 crore. One of those startups, created by three first-year undergraduates, has been valued at several million dollars.

I HOPE THAT **THE VARIOUS EDUCATIONAL REGULATORY BODIES LEARN TO STEP BACK A LITTLE** AND NOT KEEP ISSUING ONE DIKTAT AFTER ANOTHER

I can see that 2025 shall lead to the sprouting and even flowering of many worthy initiatives across several parts of India in the context of heading towards a knowledge economy. For one, several of our IITs have lent their weight to this objective. At IIT Bombay, I have been closely involved in a marvellous national initiative known as eYantra. Its objective has been to engender the creation of knowledge and entrepreneurship through a hands-on approach in the areas of robotics and AI in several colleges and universities of the country. As I see it, in 2025, several of the eYantra initiatives shall see much happening in this field in the country. For instance, in Jammu and Kashmir, eYantra has been making significant progress for some time. We are now poised to witness, in the coming year, a major initiative in many institutions where I expect much knowledge-based entrepreneurship shall happen through special engineering kitchens as a part of the curriculum. I am also further emboldened to be so very hopeful that India is moving in the right direction for becoming a knowledge economy because of the results that are becoming so very forcefully evident in the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir. Through the J&K Higher Education Council, we have been able to create a very empowered undergraduate degree programme that has been formally anointed as Design Your Degree (DYD). Incidentally, eYantra has been incorporated into the DYD initiative. This programme has now achieved stability and momentum at some of the leading universities of J&K. It has been hailed by many in India and abroad. The parliamentary standing committee on education—a few months ago—has directed the University Grants Commission to ensure its implementation in the rest of the nation. Entrepreneurship has become a natural cornerstone of this DYD programme. All this has happened through the NEP. In the coming year, I expect to see significant milestones being established by some of the universities of J&K such as the University of Jammu, the Islamic University of Science and Technology and the University of Kashmir where knowledge-based entrepreneurial ideas are beginning to show results.

My only worry is that we need to be vigilant and ensure that the spirit of the NEP remains alive and fruitful at the ground level in 2025 and beyond. I sincerely hope that the various regulatory bodies learn to step back a little and not keep issuing one diktat after another. Instead, they must encourage universities and colleges to lay stress on ensuring that the quality of our human resources is adequately trained and motivated to stay the course for the next several years. ■

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